INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT CALCUTTA

MBA Term – 6 / CEMS-MIM (Term 2)

Session 2025-26

OB-241 - Global Leadership

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Meeting time	Prior appointment over email

Introduction

The course is designed to inculcate leadership skills suited to work in international, global or cross-cultural context. The focus on the OB side or the human side with primary emphasis being on developing oneself into a better leader.

This fits into the common goals of IIMC and CEMS-MIM that indicate development of a managerial/leadership mindset that is ready to take on the challenges posed by multi- cultural environment. The primary concern of a multicultural leader is to manage people in international settings and from different culture while ensuring responsible behavior, sustainability, openness and inclusivity. The ability to work with people from different cultures has been found to be an important predictor for team success in multicultural business environment. Those skilled in mitigating such challenges are expected to stand a better chance in proving their mettle in the business world. This course introduces the participants to the basics of what it takes to create a mindset conducive to managing or leading across cultural boundaries. It would then build the perspective to develop the necessary skills for managing and leading businesses in cross-cultural context.

Keeping this in mind, the course desires to achieve:

(i) Understanding of requirements to be a leader, and a leader in global context

(ii) Sensitivity towards issues in deciphering, understanding and managing intricacies faced in interactions among people from different cultures

(iii) Knowledge of core issues to adjust to a new geography, teams and various situations

(iv) Encourage reflection on instances and learning from them

(v) Charting out course for the future (managing self and career)

The idea is to develop an attitude of understanding other people's assumptions, beliefs and values that are rooted in their own culture.

The requirements of managers form the bedrock of this course. Therefore, the course includes tools such as cases from real business situations, simulations to drive home the need for sensitization. Most of times we shall have data based discussions before we arrive at a more plausible conclusion. An open mind would help in better understanding the cases and deciphering the learning(s) therein.

CEMS-MIM Objectives

CEMS-MIM specifies a few objectives that are to be attained in all courses of the program. The five objectives are:

1) Internationalism: The course should consistently focus on international and multicultural settings and challenges and promote internationalism as value, attitude and approach to cultural, social and gender differences.

2) Business Embeddedness: The course should engage corporate partners as guest speakers, providers of "live cases" (real challenges put to the class for discussion/ solution).

3) Responsible Citizenship: The course should challenge participants to discover, challenge and develop their own values, attitudes and behavior, and to reflect on and take responsibility for the broader environment in which their actions take place.

4) Reflective Critical Thinking: The course should employ a managerial decision-making approach including reflecting on consequences of decisions and actions.

5) Comprehensive Leadership: Students should be able to reflect on their own strengths and weaknesses, their values and behaviors, and how their actions as leaders impact other people, organizations, society and the environment.

This course addresses all five objectives of the program. Session outline has session-wise fit with these objectives.

Participant Profile

Participation in this course is open to all relevant student members. Some exposure to cross-cultural context is desirable. Students from varied cultural backgrounds are encouraged to join. Having a multicultural group coming together to discuss cross-cultural issues is an interesting and learning experience.

Pedagogy

The pedagogy for this course would involve a mix of readings, case studies, group presentations, field exercises, guest speakers from industry, and in-class simulations to highlight the need for and issues involved in understanding someone

foreign or from a foreign culture. **There will be considerable emphasis on reflections on personal experiences. Participants will be encouraged to bring their lived experiences to the classroom for sharing and learning.**

Instruction Philosophy

The coordinator believes that such subjects cannot be taught. They can only be learned with individual effort to observe, explore, and distill own learning points. Learning can happen only if people wish to experience and have an open mind conducive to exploration.

The topic involved demands open discussions to share information about own assumptions, and at times, look into ourselves. Therefore, this course would follow Socratic philosophy of instruction to honour the spirit of the subject at hand. Instructor in this course would merely be a facilitator for raising issues and moderating their discussion. Meaningful class participation would be encouraged.

Course Text

There is no prescribed textbook for this course. There are several readings/articles that the students are expected to read and derive frameworks from. The basic premise is that people attend and learn this course out of interest. With that in mind, the participants are encouraged to indicate what they would like to delve deeper into. Hence, other articles and readings shall be assigned from time to time.

Module Outline

This module outline is indicative. The module sequence may shift slightly, or two modules may run in parallel depending on the schedule of the week. Such minor adjustments are necessary to keep smooth functioning of the course within the purview of institute schedule and rules. Announcements will be made via email.

Module 1: Understanding basics

Exploration Issue: What is Leadership? What does Global Leadership mean, require, and entail?

Sessions 1 and 2: Understanding Cultures, Frameworks and their Impact on us
Introduction to Global Mindset

How does culture evolve? How to decipher cultures?

Challenges of Being a Global Leader

Reflections on what we did in CEMS Term 1 / MBA Term 5

CEMS-MIM Objectives: 1, 5

Module Readings:

- Book Chapter (Exploring Culture)

- Journal of World Business articles (Javidan) on building a mindset (shared as folder)
- Javidan, M., Teagarden, M., and Bowen, D. (2010). Making it Overseas. *Harvard Business Review,* April 2010.
- Kramer, M. R., Pfitzer, M. W., & Mahne, H. (2020). How Global Leaders Should Think About Solving Our Biggest Problems. *Harvard Business Review Digital Articles*, 2–5.
- Dewhurst, M., Harris, J. & Heywood, S. (2014). Next-generation global organizations. *McKinsey Quarterly*, September 2014, 28-39.
- Meyer, E. (2017). Being the Boss in Brussels, Boston, and Beijing: If You Want to Succeed, You'll Need to Adapt. *Harvard Business Review, 95(4),* 70–77.

Sessions 3 and 4: Global Mindset at work

Stepping into a Global Leader's shoes

CASE DISCUSSION

- **Road to Hell (A)**
    - Case Q: Consider yourself in Baker's shoes. What is your assessment of Rennalls? How did you ascertain his suitability to replace you? What are your reservations about him? What are you likely to say as you handover the reins of the business to him, a local star?

ASSESSMENT ON INTERPERSONAL ROLE ORIENTATION

CEMS-MIM Objectives: 1, 3, 4, 5

Module 2: Organizational vs National Culture

Sessions 5 and 6: National Culture *vs.* Organizational Culture: Who wins?

CASE DISCUSSION

- **Four Season Goes to Paris**
    - How does Four Seasons (does not) adapt its new hotel in Paris? What is the role of the leader in ensuring the transition?

Student Led project presentation (2 nos.) – Graded (Draw by lottery)

- Was Renault-Nissan merger/alliance Japanese or French? How did Carlos Ghosn manage himself and the firm?
- What is more important for the organizations? Being global? Being local? How should leaders make those choices?

Module 3: Cross Cultural Variations

Sessions 7 and 8: GROUP PRESENTATIONS – Leadership requirements in cultural blocks

In class group presentations on assigned cultural cluster (GLOBE studies) to the remaining groups. What are the unique elements of that cluster, and what kind of leadership behaviors are expected in those clusters? **You need to show evidence through deeper search including the videos. The presentation will be graded.**

Module 4: Cross Cultural Communication Problems

Sessions 9 and 10: Can culture influence in a low-context communication setup?

CASE DISCUSSION

- **Johannes Van Den Bosch Sends an Email**
  - Case Q: What do you think of the email written by Johannes Van den Bosch? What salient features do you think it has that would have desired impact on the recipient (Pablo Menendez)?

SIMULATION

- **Tip of the Iceberg**
- IN-CLASS SIMULATION – BRING LAPTOPS

CEMS-MIM Objectives: 1, 2, 3, 4

Module Readings:

- Hall, E. (1960). The Silent Language in Overseas Business. *Harvard Business Review, 38(3)*: 87-96.
- Meyer, E. (2014). Navigating the cultural minefield. *Harvard Business Review, 92(5)*, 119-123.
- Larson, B. Z., & Makarius, E. E. (2018). The Virtual Work Skills You Need -- Even If You Never Work Remotely. *Harvard Business Review Digital Articles*, 1–5.

Module 5: Managing International/Multicultural Teams

Sessions 11 and 12: Building a Team

CASE DISCUSSION

- **(Re)Building a Global Team: Tariq Khan at Tek**
  - Case Q: If you are Tariq, what are the challenges you are facing with this team? What is your analysis? What are considerations for or against taking this assignment up?

Module Readings:

- Mortensen, M. (2015). A First-Time Manager's Guide to Leading Virtual Teams. *Harvard Business Review Digital Articles*, 2-5.
- Edmondson, A. C. (2012). Teamwork On the Fly. *Harvard Business Review, 90(4):* 72- 80.

- Brett, J., Behfar, K., & Kern, M. C. (2006). Managing Multicultural Teams. *Harvard Business Review, 84(11)*: 84-91.
- Meyer, E. (2014). How to Say "This Is Crap" In Different Cultures. *Harvard Business Review Digital Articles*, 2–4.

Sessions 13 and 14: Simulation – Making a high stakes team work

Simulation: Everest V3

- IN-CLASS SIMULATION – BRING LAPTOPS

Module 6: Cross-Cultural Complexity in Negotiations

Sessions 15 and 16: Negotiating to Win

SIMULATION (IN-CLASS EXERCISE)

- **Tripartite Negotiation game** (needs three classrooms)

CEMS-MIM Objectives: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5

Readings:

- Myer, E. (2015). Getting to Si, Ja, Oui, Hai, and Da: How to Negotiate across cultures. *Harvard Business Review, 93(12)*: 74-80.

Module 7: Being a Successful Expatriate and Change Agent

Sessions 17 and 18: Dealing with crisis

CASE DISCUSSION 1

- **Joe Willis feels the heat in Thailand**
  - Case Q: Put yourself in Joe Willis' shoes. What is the situation assessment at Fasco Motors Thailand? What challenges does Joe Willis and colleagues face on (i) professional front, and (ii) personal front? What can they do to deal with those challenges?

Exploration issue: Adjusting to expat life and delivering results CEMS-MIM Objectives: 1, 2, 3, 5

CASE DISCUSSION 2

- **KEMET: Leading Change Across Cultural Boundaries**
  - Case Q: What is the issue at hand? What does your knowledge of Change Management tell you about the plan of action? Is there something that you find peculiar or odd or strangely missing?

Exploration issue: Change Management – The Ultimate Test

CEMS-MIM Objectives: 1, 2, 3, 5

Module Readings:

- Mendenhall, M. E. & Stahl, G. K. (2000). Expatriate training and development: Where do we go from here? *Human Resource Management*, 39, 251-265.
- Black, J. S. & Gregersen, H. B. (1999). The right way to manage expats. *Harvard Business Review*, March-April, 52-62.

Module 8: Knowing, Doing, Being

Sessions 19 and 20: Know your career preference, Boss Management, Managing Self

CASE DISCUSSION

- **Thomas Green: Power, Politics, and a Career in Crisis**
  - Case Q: How did you (Thomas Green) land in this situation? Who is responsible? What are your options and what will you do?

CAREER ANCHOR INVENTORY – Filling up and Discussion

Evaluation Criteria

- Positive contribution to case discussion: 30% (Quality, Active/ Enthusiastic Participation, attendance will have some weightage)
- Group Projects: 30% (Presentations)
- Individual Assignment (Reflection) and Feedback Seeking: 40% (25+15)

Individual Assignment – Idea is to help the participants reflect and be self aware.

- One page => A4 size, 1" margin on all sides, 11 pt Times New Roman, 1.15 line spacing.
- References, title/cover page will not be counted.

There are two options that the instructor could think of. You may think of other possibilities and negotiate.

Option 1: Personal Leadership Reflection Assignment

- Your lived cross-cultural experience and your demonstration of leadership capabilities – You have to write a 2000-5000 words (5-10 pages approx) case based on your personal experience(s) in global travel or living abroad scenario the last two years. You need not worry about success or failure outcomes. You must focus on the facts. It's a great learning opportunity.
  (I understand that failures will be vivid and painful to remember, and success will be immensely recountable).
  <u>You also need to present a report analysing what happened, why did you get the outcome that you got? How did you contribute to it? Would you like to do something different the next time a similar situation arises? And why?</u>

You may use concepts from readings (additional readings) and class discussions. You may also make recommendations about what could you have done differently. Please be specific and don't globe around.

- In case you don't have cross-cultural experience in the last two years, you may actively build an intercultural experience through immersion in a subculture within the country, or doing community service for the sector that you have had no prior exposure to. The idea is to stretch your boundaries by spending time with a different group, test your intercultural skills, and learn how to perceive the world through the eyes of people who are different and unfamiliar. You may even choose such different people on campus.
  You would need to submit a 5-10 page report describing the experiences you made and how you coped with the situation along with analysis of what happened and why. This will not be easy, but will be an immense learning experience.

List your strengths and areas of improvement at the end of the course based on the analysis of the write up. Be specific and show clear connection.

Option 2: You need to choose and work on any one of the following

1) **Learning about a Company**
   Company analysis of a specific management issue that an organization in particular is facing. It could be based on secondary data search. It could be a firm that you have worked for, or are looking to work for, or you have been following in the news. You may consider yourself to be an investigative journalist or a consultant when you analyse the challenges facing the company. The closer the challenge to global/inter- cultural leadership, the better it is.
2) **Learning from Leaders**
   You may interview executives, consultants, diplomats, thought leaders based on a format that you have designed in the group. The interview data will then need to be put together, analysed and presented with major theme(s) in the form of a paper.
   Interview notes are to be attached with the paper.
3) **Video Analysis**
   You may choose to analyse a movie or a string of movies or documentaries related to inter-cultural experience. You would need to identify cultural issues or themes. Even series of commercials for the same product across the world may qualify. You may think of other possibilities. Videos may be

analysed from a ***comparative*** (e.g., how negotiation processes differ between China, Germany, and the U.S.) or ***an inter- cultural perspective*** (e.g., focusing on issues that would be important for a manager, if transplanted abroad or into a cross-cultural workplace situation).

These projects will be submitted in video or written form.

PLEASE NOTE: Given the nature of the assignments and course objectives, option two is inherently less valuable than option one. This may also reflect in marks.

Discussion questions for cases will be handed to you via email for easy online access in the previous week.

Feel free to clarify doubts with the instructor.

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